



THE 7 HABITS OF HIGHLY EFFECTIVE PEOPLE

Powerful Lessons in Personal Change

by Stephen R. Covey

The Big “So What” ???

The book presents a **holistic and principle-centered approach to achieve success through positive change from within**. Covey’s 7 habits were based on a review of some 200 years of success literature, and his ideas still form the foundation for many personal development books and programs today.

Introduction



To become more effective, you need to increase your Production(of desired results) and Production Capacity (the capacity to deliver such results). A central idea of his book is **to improve P/ PC from “inside-out”, i.e. start with change within oneself**. This goes beyond merely improving one’s skills or knowledge, but deals fundamentally with who you are, or who you become as an individual. The habits are progressive in nature, though there’s no need to perfect one habit before moving on to the next. Each habit sets the foundation for the next level:



Dependence => Independence:

Habits 1-3 provide your “Private Victories” as you develop your character and self-mastery.



Independence => Interdependence:

Habits 4-6 shift how you interact with others, to form trusting relationships with healthy emotional bank accounts. These are your “Public Victories.”



Renewal:

Habit 7 creates an upward growth spiral as you continually renew and grow yourself and hone the 6 previous habits.

KEY QUOTES

“Inside-Out” approach

“Change - real change - comes from the Inside-Out... It comes from striking at the root - the fabric of our thought, the fundamental, essential paradigms, which give definition to our character and create the lens through which we see the world”.

“Inside-Out” means to start first with self; even more fundamentally, to start with the most inside part of self -- with your paradigms, your character, and your motives”.

“Although the habits are sequential, improvement in one habit synergistically increases your ability to live the rest”.

Independence

“Real self-respect comes from dominion over self, from true independence... Interdependence is a choice only independent people can make.”

Habit 1: Be Proactive



This essentially means to **take full responsibility for your lives and choices**. To be proactive, you should:



Take the initiative:

No matter what your circumstances are, or what happens in your life, **you have total freedom to choose your responses**. When you take the initiative to be response-able, you empower ourselves to create your situations and not vice versa.



Choose proactive language:

Use proactive language like “I can”, “I will”, “I choose to”. Avoid language like “I can’t”, “I have to”...



Focus on your Circle of Influence.

Focus your energy on your Circle of Influence, i.e. areas you can do something about. One area that is fully within your control is who you want to “be”, i.e. how you think and act. This is opposed to the Circle of Concern, i.e. areas you have little or no control over, e.g. national economy, the weather.

Habit 2: Begin with the End in Mind



This is the **habit of personal leadership**. It is about **having a clear vision in your mind on your end destination and goals**. This is important because everything happens first in your mind before becoming reality in the physical form. To get started:



Develop a Personal Mission Statement.

This should map out **who you want to be, what you wish to accomplish in life, and the values or principles which will define who you are**. This statement will guide your daily tasks and priorities.

KEY QUOTES

Responsibility

“Response-ability (is) the ability to choose your response.”

Begin with the End

“This habit is called Personal Leadership because leadership is considered to be the first creation of your vision, and management comes in second and productivity third.”



Examine the centre.

This involves identifying what is most important to you. This centre is also the source of 4 life-support factors: Security (it gives you personal strength and self-worth), Guidance (it guides your decisions and life direction), Wisdom (it is your source of perspective and balance) and Power (it is your source of strength to make choices and accomplish something).

When you centre your life around unwavering internal principles (as opposed to external factors like your family, spouses, money or career) you will have a more stable foundation for personal effectiveness.

Habit 3: Put First Things First



With clear priorities identified and created mentally (Habit 2), you move into the habit of personal-management. This is where you exercise willpower and discipline, to organise and implement activities that translate your goals into reality.

	urgent	not urgent
important	Quadrant I	Quadrant II
not important	Quadrant III	Quadrant IV

Using the time-management matrix above, Covey explains that your goal is to prioritise time for Quadrant II activities, and he lays out 6 key principles of effective Quadrant II management:



Coherence:

Your personal mission statement is aligned with and reflected in everything you desire, plan and do.



Balance:

There is balance and due attention given to various important areas like your family, health and personal growth.



“People” Dimension:

Besides adhering to an efficient schedule, give focus to effective dealings with other people.

KEY QUOTES

“As a principle-centered person... you have a high degree of security, guidance, wisdom, and power that flows from a solid, unchanging core.”

Put First Things First

“It's the exercise of independent will toward becoming principle-centered. It's the day-in, day-out, moment-by-moment doing it.”

“Most people say their main fault is a lack of discipline... I believe that is not the case. The basic problem is that their priorities have not become deeply planted in their hearts and minds. They haven't really internalized Habit 2.”



Flexibility:

Use planning tools, but don't become a servant to them.



Portability:

Ensure your tools (including your personal mission statement) are portable and can follow you most of the time.



Focus:

To ensure you are preventing and not prioritising crisis, Covey recommends **weekly planning, with 4 key activities**:

a) *Identify Roles* : Write down the key roles in your life

b) *Select Goals* : Identify 2-3 key results to achieve for each role in the coming week, incorporating Quadrant II activities.

c) *Schedule* : Plan the week ahead and set aside time for these goals.

d) *Adapt Daily* : Adjust activities to manage unexpected developments.

Habit 4: Think win-win



This is **the habit of interpersonal relationship**. Win-win is a mind-set and philosophy built on **an approach of achieving mutual benefit for the parties involved**. Where a win-win solution cannot be reached, consider agreeing to disagree amicably, rather than “force” a deal. **To achieve win-win, there are 5 dimensions, each built on the previous layer**:



Character

There are 3 critical character traits for win-win:

- **Integrity**: Being true to your values, commitments and feelings
- **Maturity**: Blending courage (to express your ideas and feelings) and consideration (for others' ideas and feelings)
- **Abundance Mindset**: The belief that there is more than enough for everyone

KEY QUOTES

“The key is not to prioritize what's on your schedule, but to schedule your priorities”.

Think win-win

“Win-win is not a technique; it's a total philosophy of human interaction”.



Relationships

Built based on trust and a **positive Emotional Bank Account**. The EBA is a key foundation to interdependence, and there are 6 ways to make a deposit or grow the account.

- Understand the other person
- Attend to the Little Things (e.g. small acts of kindness and courtesy)
- Keep Commitments or promises
- Clarify Expectations (and assumptions)
- Show Personal Integrity (i.e. tell the truth and be true to our words regardless of whether we are watched)
- Apologize sincerely when you make a withdrawal



Agreements

Establish a framework for win-win, including the desired results, guidelines, resources, accountability and consequences.



Supportive Systems

Free people up to concentrate on win-win.



Processes

Use processes that facilitate win-win outcomes.

Habit 5: Seek First to Understand, Then to be Understood



This is the **habit of communication**, and it is built on empathic listening. Empathic listening represents an entire paradigm shift because it is not about applying listening skills, but **“listening with intent to understand”**. This is opposed to how most people listen – with the intent to speak or respond; They are still in their own frame of reference, not that of the other person’s.

Covey stresses that Habits 1-3 are critical because empathic listening opens you up to influence by others. Without a “changeless inner core”, it will be hard to manage such external influence.

KEY QUOTES

Emphatic Listening

“In empathic listening, you listen with your ears, but you also, and more importantly, listen with your eyes and with your heart... You sense, you intuit, you feel”.

“When we really, deeply understand each other, we open the door to creative solutions and Third Alternatives”.

When you listen emphatically, you use both sides of your brain, and you are able to respond by both rephrasing the content in your own words, and reflecting how the other party feels. This habit is applicable to all areas of life, as you need to “**diagnose before you prescribe**”.

Habit 6: Synergize



This is the **habit of creative co-operation**, where “the whole is greater than the sum of its parts”.

“The essence of synergy is to value differences” and “the key to valuing those differences is to realize that all people see the world, not as it is, but as they are”. You will inevitably have mental, emotional and psychological differences in your perceptions compared with others. When you acknowledge that people are all ‘correct’ in their different perspectives, and are prepared to “value this difference”, you gain new knowledge and understanding of reality, and open up Third Alternatives.

Synergy brings about a catalytic, mind-expanding, creative process which can be both exciting and scary. This is because you are letting go of old paradigms, and co-creating new paths or options that previously didn’t exist. Often, you don’t know where exactly those paths will lead you.

Habit 7: Sharpen the Saw



This is **the habit of self-renewal**, and has a synergistic impact on all the other habits. There are 4 key dimensions to be renewed regularly:



Physical:

To preserve and enhance the capacity of your physical bodies, you need to care effectively for it, including eating right, getting sufficient rest, and exercising regularly.

KEY QUOTES

Valuing differences

“The key to valuing ...differences is to realize that all people see the world, not as it is, but as they are.”

“When you communicate synergistically, you are simply opening your mind and heart and expressions to new possibilities, new alternatives, new options”.

Sharpening the Saw

“Renewal is the principle -- and the process -- that empowers us to move on an upward spiral of growth and change, of continuous improvement ... (it) requires us to learn, commit, and do on increasingly higher planes”.



Spiritual:

To continually strengthen your core or center, through reading, music, nature, meditation, prayer or other means.



Mental:

To continually expand and hone your mind, through external study programs, examination of your inner programming and paradigms, or reading and writing to sharpen your mental insights and clarity.



Social/ Emotional:

To deliberately practice habits 4-6 in your daily interactions with other people.

All 4 dimensions are interrelated and **must be renewed in a balanced way**. In fact, when we sharpen the saw in any one dimension, it creates **positive synergistic effects** on the other dimensions and our 7 habits.

As we develop interdependence, **we have the awareness, power and choice to affirm and reflect back to others a positive reflection of themselves, and hence empower and uplift others**. “The more we can see people in terms of their unseen potential, the more we can use our imagination rather than our memory...we can “see” them in new fresh ways each time we’re with them”.

Other Useful Details in the Book to Look Out For



The 7 habits in the book may seem simple, but may not be easy to implement in real life. Covey elaborates on each of the concepts and ideas with details and examples, so we understand how to apply them. He also provides many practical tips including:

1. Application suggestions on how to apply each of the 7 Habits.
2. Practical tips and small details that affect the effectiveness of how each habit is executed, e.g. the importance of using

KEY QUOTES

visualizations and affirmations in developing and reviewing Personal Mission Statements.

3. Example and illustrations to help us understand the 7 habits, including application at a personal and family/ organizational level.

About the Author of The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People

Dr. Stephen Richards Covey was an American businessman, educator, author, and keynote speaker. Besides *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*, some of his more popular books include *First Things First*, *Principle-Centered Leadership*, *The 8th Habit*, and *The Leader In Me*.



Covey was one of the most influential thought leaders on leadership, strategy and individual effectiveness. In 1996, he was named one of Time magazine's 25 Most Influential Americans. He founded the Covey Leadership Center, which later became FranklinCovey Co., after a merger with Franklin Quest in 1997.

More resources can be found at www.stephencovey.com.

KEY QUOTES
